On weekdays, Modi was busy criss-crossing the battleground states which were going to the assembly polls—he did fifty-five rallies in four states in October and November alone. ‘This was carpet-bombing, part one, a trailer for the general elections that were to follow,’ says an aide. The stakes were high—in all the four election states, the BJP was in a direct contest with the Congress. If the BJP could sweep these states, it would be the ideal launch pad for the 2014 elections; the Congress, by contrast, would be demoralized by defeat.

The key state in the Modi game plan was Rajasthan. Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh had strong BJP chief ministers in office—even in victory, the glory would have to be shared. Delhi had been complicated by the entry of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP). Rajasthan, though, was a state that could serve as a laboratory to test Modi’s appeal beyond Gujarat. Bordering Gujarat, it had a large tribal and rural population. ‘If we could score a big win in Rajasthan, we would know we were on the right track and our campaign was making a dent beyond our traditional voters,’ was how a Modi strategist described it.

It helped that the BJP’s chief ministerial candidate for Rajasthan, Vasundhara Raje, was someone Modi got along with. Raje, like Modi, was a fierce individualist. She had endured her fair share of run-ins with the patriarchal male-dominated RSS leadership in the state and wouldn’t be bullied into submission easily. Their private lives couldn’t have been more different. Raje likes her occasional glass of wine, is often spotted at Page Three events, has even walked the ramp and celebrates her birthdays with much joie de vivre. Modi, of course, leads a more austere life, though he’s partial to his designer kurtas, pens, watches and glasses, and even, I am told, shoes. And yet, the two of them made a good team. I once asked Raje what she liked about Modi. Her answer was breezily aristocratic. ‘He is a man of action who doesn’t bullshit around like the rest!’

It was in Rajasthan that Team Modi spent most of its energies in the 2013 elections. One of the campaign strategies here was to send 200 GPS-enabled mobile vans or digital raths with 50-inch LED screens across the state to reach out to far-flung villages where traditional media could not